

Pahankanuwa Sermon #3

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Nagarim̐ yathā paccantaṃ,

guttaṃ santarabāhiraṃ;

Evam̐ gopetha attānaṃ,

khaṇo vo mā upaccagā;

Khaṇātītā hi socanti,

nirayamhi samappitā.

From:

Verse 315, from the Nirayavagga (Chapter on Hell) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Our Father, the Teacher of the Three Worlds, the Fully Self-Awakened One, having practiced difficult austerities for six years, discovered the Path to Nibbāna, namely, the Four Noble Truths. He first revealed this to the world of gods and humans on an Esala Full Moon Poya Day. Therefore, today is an extremely valuable Poya day. Moreover, looking at it from another perspective, it can be considered a day of great dispensary value to the Dispensation (*sāsana*). When taken as a Poya day that marks the beginning of the rainy-season retreat (*vassa*) of the Sangha, this Esala Full Moon Poya Day is a highly significant day. Now, the term used in ancient texts for what we call the Buddha Dispensation (*Buddha Sāsana*) is "Dhamma-Vinaya" (Doctrine and Discipline). "Dhamma-Vinaya" is applied to describe the Dispensation of the Teacher because both the

Dhamma and the Vinaya are relevant to it. When considering the rainy season, it is particularly connected with a set of disciplinary rules of the Sangha, and therefore this rainy season is considered a highly important period from the perspective of the Vinaya. However, in the time of the Buddha, we see from ancient stories that the rainy-season retreat was also considered an extremely valuable period from the perspective of the Dhamma, from the aspect of the Doctrine. For there was a custom in the Buddha's time: during the period when the Buddha was living, the members of the Sangha, before the rainy-season retreat, would go to meet the Buddha, obtain a meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*), go to a remote, secluded area, observe the rainy-season retreat in a suitable place, meditate according to that meditation subject, and endeavor by all means to realize Nibbāna within that rainy season and bring that joyful news back to the Buddha. There was a great eagerness among those monks. Looking at it in this light, the wise and far-sighted Sangha of that era considered the realization of Nibbāna as the highest and noblest meritorious deed to be performed during a rainy-season retreat—as the ultimate *vassa*-merit. If, despite striving as much as possible and exerting effort during those three months, they were unable to realize Nibbāna, a sense of spiritual urgency (*saṃvega*) would arise within those monks. Why? Because when they returned to meet the Buddha after the rainy-season retreat, the question the Buddha usually asked, after first inquiring about their well-being in a friendly, conversational manner, was: "Monks, have you fulfilled the purpose of your ordination?" If they could not answer this properly, it would cause a great listlessness and hesitation in the minds of those monks. To put it briefly, it would be like returning empty-handed from a journey to see the Buddha. That is why the Sangha made a great effort to realize Nibbāna during the rainy-season retreat. Now, a story that clarifies these matters is connected to the stanza we took as our theme.

During a time when the Buddha was residing at Jetavana monastery, a group of monks went to a remote border village—even though we use the word "remote," what is meant there is a village situated on the frontier—to observe the rainy-season retreat. During the first month, those monks were able to carry out their meditation activities well. The support and offerings of the lay devotees were excellent. However, in the second month, a band of thieves—a gang of robbers—invaded that village and took the villagers captive. Thereafter, the villagers began to set up security measures. Fearing that the gang of robbers would return and attack in this manner, they began to establish defenses. Building various kinds of ramparts and protective walls, they set up various security systems along the streets. Because of this, difficulties arose for the monks. Consequently, somehow or other, these monks were unable to fulfill the purpose they had hoped for.

When these monks went to see the Buddha after the rainy-season retreat, the Buddha asked, "How was it, monks, did you spend the rainy-season retreat comfortably and in peace?" Then these monks complained: "Venerable Sir, during the first month indeed we lived well without any trouble. Thereafter, robbers invaded, and due to the situation that arose in the village, the villagers—the lay devotees—directed their minds towards establishing security measures, which led to various shortcomings for us. We were unable to practice our Dhamma and meditation properly during the rainy-season retreat." They expressed this as their excuse. At that moment, the Buddha declared: "Monks, it is indeed so. A comfortable and easy lodging is not something that is obtained every day. It is not something to be constantly expected. That is the normal nature of things. But what should have been done by you? Just as those people protected their city, you should have protected yourselves. Just as those people were diligent in protecting their village, you ought to have secured your own protection." Thus declaring, he spoke the verse we introduced as our theme earlier:

Nagaram yathā paccantam

guttam santarabāhiram

evam gopetha attānam

khaṇo ve mā upaccagā

khaṇātītā hi socanti

nirayamhi samappitā

The meaning of this is: just as a city situated on the frontier is well-guarded inside and out—internally and externally—just as a frontier city is provided with excellent internal and external protection, in that very same manner—*evam gopetha attānam*—so one must secure one's own protection. *Evam gopetha attānam - khaṇo ve mā upaccagā*—the next phrase indicates that these tasks must be performed diligently: *khaṇo ve mā upaccagā*—do not let the moment—the right moment—pass you by. Do not allow the moment—the opportunity—to slip away. *Khaṇo ve mā upaccagā*. Next, the danger of not being properly heedful of this advice is expressed in the next two lines: *khaṇātītā hi socanti - nirayamhi samappitā*. If one allows the moment to pass by, what happens to such people? *Khaṇātītā hi socanti*—they will have to cry, lament, feel regret, and sorrow. *Nirayamhi samappitā*—why? Because having fallen into hell—falling into hell, they will have to suffer. In this manner, the Buddha delivered an instructive, advisory verse. It is said there that upon hearing this verse, those

venerable monks attained Arahantship. Now, when we reflect based on this verse, we see the deep Dhamma contained within it. Monks direct their minds to Dhamma and meditation, putting effort into those activities, and just as if completing some lack in them, the Buddha delivers this Dhamma verse in many instances. Therefore, we can understand that even a single statement of Dhamma, a single verse of the Buddha, helps in bringing the efforts of those monks to their culmination and in completing their meditation subjects. That must be why it is mentioned that the monks attained Arahantship upon merely hearing the verse. Be that as it may, let us reflect upon the depth of this Dhamma verse according to our own capacity.

Now, this simile is very beautiful. The reason we follow a simile in these instances is that a simile helps the Dhamma point to descend deep into the mind.

Nagaram yathā paccantam - guttam santarabāhiraṃ—we can understand that this simile is highly appropriate for this day and age as well. Here, it speaks of protecting a city situated on the frontier, both inside and out. Likewise, the monks are told, *evaṃ gopetha attānaṃ*—secure your self-protection in this manner. Even today, "self-protection" is a term commonly used. But nowadays, when we say "self-protection", it generally refers to physical safety—protecting the body. Using it in the sense of physical protection to guard the body. As for the mind—perhaps there is a concept in the world that it does not matter if it is handed over to the devil or Mara. However, what the Buddha declared here as "self-protection" (protecting oneself) is the guarding of the mind. For what we carry along in this saṃsāra is this mind—the mental continuum. This body, this physical cage, is abandoned and left behind. Therefore, the Buddha actually gave greater weight to guarding the mind. Here too, the meaning to be taken is not merely guarding the body, but guarding the mind. To guard the mind, a certain degree of interest in the body must arise. However, what most people do is guard the body without any concern for the mind, whatever may happen to it. So, if we take this deep meaning to be the guarding of one's mind, let us next reflect upon this system of security—about what is said here regarding protection.

If we reflect according to the Dhamma, who is the security guard of the mind? Mindfulness, awareness (*sati*). In accordance with the Dhamma, it is shown as *sati āraḁkhasāraṁhi* (mindfulness is the guarding charioteer). The task of taming the mind, the work of guarding the mind, that responsibility is borne by the sentry called mindfulness (*sati*). When this sentry called mindfulness is well-uniformed, we can understand this more broadly as mindfulness and clear comprehension (*sati-sampajañña*). For *sampajañña*, because we need a Sinhala word in some instances, we have translated it as "conscious awareness" or "knowing awareness." Otherwise, it is staying mindful with clear understanding. The clear understanding that goes hand in hand with

mindfulness. So, what is expressed here is mindfulness endowed with this conscious awareness. Now, when placing security guards in the world, in a place like a city, protection is described as being both inside and out. Usually, in a city, there is the inner gate, the entrance, then the fort walls, ramparts, etc. If looking outward, there are watchtowers, sentry boxes, moats, and so on—in the past, various measures—security measures—were deployed to protect cities. Even today, a sentry is usually stationed near a gate. When stationed near a gate, that gate must be a very narrow gate. If it is a large gate, a crowd of people can force their way in. In the same way, if we reflect on mindfulness in accordance with the Dhamma—*sati*—the word *sati* also has the meaning of memory. But when speaking of Right Mindfulness (*sammā sati*) in accordance with the Dhamma, this is always established mindfulness in the present moment. This is something relevant to the present. Because if the mind begins to run to the past, or if it begins to leap into the future, then that gate becomes wide. Then, what is the gate we have to guard? When looking at it according to the Dhamma, it is these six sense-doors: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind. Including the mind, these are the six sense-doors. The five external senses are the eye, ear, nose, tongue, and body. Then there is the mind—the mind-faculty (*manindriya*). These six sense-doors are what must be guarded. In guarding these six doors, the army of Mara, the army of defilements, the enemy host, is constantly waiting to break in. The host waiting to invade is the sense-objects. For the eye, visual objects; for the ear, sound objects; for the nose, odors. In this manner, the enemy hosts that agitate the mind, drawing it to attachment, aversion, and delusion, are waiting to invade. And they come very rapidly. In such a situation, when a large crowd comes to the gate, they must first be told, "You must come in a queue." Come in a queue, one after another. Otherwise, it cannot be guarded. Making it a narrow gate in that manner is the very way to easily anchor the mind in the present. Anchoring the mind in the present, without running to the past, without leaping to the future, and directing mindfulness to each and every thing as it comes—this is what is expressed here. Together with that mindfulness, what is done through mindfulness? A certain active limit is required. Using that conscious awareness as an aid, one reflects. A certain attention, a reflection is applied.

Let us think: if there is a security guard, his duty is not to fall asleep. Remaining fully awake and alert, he casts an inquiring eye on each person who comes. That depends on his skill. It must be done very rapidly. He cannot keep one person waiting there for a long time either. They come; then, subjecting them to an inquiring eye, if it is someone who should be let in, he lets them in. If it is someone who should be kept out, he turns them away. Only these two options exist. Therefore, what is needed here is that skill; that reflection cannot be done extensively here. 基因 Nowadays, as you well know, in such places they ask for

something called an identity card. Thus, even if not in the form of an identity card, there must have been methods of identification in the past when people arrived. On that identity card, there is a name. There is a picture. So, this person is known by this name. This person comes presenting a certain form (*rūpa*) corresponding to that identity. But what is usually done? If enemy forces come, if spies come, they come in disguise. Not in their true form. Therefore, they must be recognized. If he is a highly skilled sentry, without letting them engage in irrelevant chatter, he must make them present their identity card and prove their eligibility to enter. In that same way, if we reflect according to the Dhamma, these incoming objects—these enemy hosts—have a common method of identification. That is called Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). They are recognized by reflecting on them as Name-and-Form. Now, let us say a form (*rūpa*) comes forward. Some object/form comes. This is something that happens to the insight meditator (*vipassanā-bhāvanāyogī*). Then, this incoming form comes in disguise. They are called color-configurations—their colors, various kinds of colors. Then, various other shapes. Because of this, the mind might become distinctive/involved. Without directing the mind to those—"this is a form." Then, that meditator, whatever kind of form comes, reflects on it as "form, form" (*rūpa, rūpa*). He does not go any further than that. Why? The reason the Buddha has shown is that if one is to go further than that, the mind cannot be stopped. It gets dragged into defilements. Those are called signs (*nimitta*) and features (*anuvyañjana*). That means, taking a sign, and taking other characteristics associated with the sign. When that person sees the form—when he sees some person or some thing—since various other thoughts—thoughts of defilement—can invade regarding it, he reflects on it briefly as "a form."

Likewise, relevant to this, what is to be considered here, in brief, are the three characteristics: the three characteristics of impermanent (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*). It is by applying these three characteristics that everything is passed through. So, what helps to apply those three characteristics—to recognize this, there is nothing else here. Now, name-dhamma (mental factors), as shown in accordance with the Dhamma, are feeling (*vedanā*), perception (*saññā*), volition (*cetanā*), contact (*phassa*), and attention (*manasikāra*). Now, the attempt is to parallel this with the Dhamma. Name-dhammas are generally things connected to the mind. So, the things connected to the mind here are feelings (*vedanā*). A person recognizes something—even a small child who does not yet know how to speak recognizes things—through such things. A certain experiencing. Or else, experiencing something given to them, based on the feeling in it. Or else, a certain perception through it. Then, a thought that arises regarding it, their contact (*phassa*). The way we reflect on them. In this way, when looking deeply, these are the name-

dhammas that help insight meditation (*vipassanā*). Next, when taking form-dhammas (*rūpa-dhamma*) too, one does not think about those previously mentioned color-configurations or color-shapes. All these things, as many as there are in the world, our body, and external things—what are the primary elements (*mūla dhātu*) they are made of? Earth (*pathavī*), water (*āpo*), fire (*tejo*), air (*vāyo*). This great earth and our body are made of that solid nature called earth. Next, water, which is of a flowing nature—indicated by water. Next, fire, which is heat. Next, wind, which is air. It is of things relevant to these four that our body and external things are made. Because of this, when reflecting according to the Dhamma, that is how the sentry called mindfulness (*sati*) has to understand through attention. He does not let the mind run along other external signs of the incoming form, because defilements would flow in. If we take it as Name-and-Form in this way, this is the identity card. We pass these through after checking this identity card. Now an object has come. It is not held back. It has gone. It came and went, came and went. Through that, we understand the impermanent nature—the arising and passing nature of all of these. In this way indeed, the eye, ear, nose, etc., function. Now, a sound—when we stop a word, a certain contact (*phassa*) comes to the ear along with it. Now, in things like a rabana (one-sided drum) or a drum, after something strikes it, an echo also sounds for a long time. When striking something like a rabana, an echo comes naturally. Similarly, the thoughts that arise in the mind through words, a certain echo comes regarding them too. That is why they can be remembered again. They are remembered. In this way indeed, concerning the ear. One can think about each of these. Concerning the tongue, even a small child can easily understand. Thus, in all of these, these objects come flowing in. They come very rapidly. Now, the meditator, in a manner that does not lead to being dragged along or pulled by them, in a manner that does not cause attachment, recognizes them with a certain middle measure. Within that recognition, within that reflection, wisdom (*paññā*) becomes active. Then, if one is to realize Nibbāna, both mindfulness (*sati*) and wisdom (*paññā*) must be developed. This wisdom becomes active at that moment through that reflection. That is to say, using mindfulness, a recognition of this is done. It must be done very rapidly. The reason for this is that the Buddha has declared that the objects flowing into our senses in this world come very rapidly. On one occasion, the Buddha declared to the young Brahmin Ajita:

Yāni sotāni lokasmim

sati tesam nivāraṇam

sotānam samvaram brūmi

paññāyete pidhīyare

—(*Sutta Nipāta, v. 1039*)

"Whatever streams there are in the world, mindfulness is their barrier. I call mindfulness the restraint of the streams. But they are shut off by wisdom." Whatever flowing streams of water there are in the world, mindfulness—this awareness called *sati*—is the way to obstruct them. Obstruction—*sati tesam nivāraṇaṃ*, *sotānaṃ saṁvaram brūmi*, I declare this to be the method of blocking these flowing streams. *Paññāyete pidhīyare*, but actually, all these can be closed, the streams can be completely shut off, by wisdom. Then, by this mindfulness—just as in a river flowing with a certain speed, one cannot build a dam all at once. One has to use some device to block the flowing water to some extent. Just as the security guard stops the invading crowd, saying "wait a moment." Then, subjects them to inspection. Through subjecting them to inspection, he understands that person's true nature. If it is an object of defilement, he pushes it away entirely. In that way, even with water, it is only after the dam is built that it is complete. Wisdom is the dam. Wisdom, deep understanding, realization of the Dhamma. The true nature of this.

So, here we have a matter relevant to meditation. It must have been by understanding based on this that those monks attained Arahantship. Thus, what is said here is the guarding of the mind; the mind is the city. This is said to have six gates. Through these six gates, what is called the mind is the thoughts that come to the mind. Apart from that, other external objects: forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and touches. When these are flowing in, applying mindfulness, applying conscious awareness accompanied by mindfulness, one must reflect on each and every one. And that reflection must be done very rapidly. It is not about saying it at length. If it is a form, a form, "form, form." If it is a sound, a sound, "sound, sound"—saying it twice. "Form, form," "sound, sound"—giving that designation to the mind. Through that designating, understanding it, one brings it to an end right there. It is this kind of discipline that one employs in meditation, in insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*). This is the meaning that the Buddha has expressed through this verse. In short, it is about Nibbāna that is expressed here. The qualities that help towards Nibbāna. That is why the Buddha declares next, *khaṇo ve mā upaccagā*—do not let the opportunity to realize Nibbāna pass you by. This moment—the possession of the opportune moment (*khaṇa-sampatti*)—is described in this Dhamma. The Buddha has declared that the human existence obtained during a time of a Buddha's appearance—one's whole life—must be considered as a single moment. The Buddha declares: "Monks, people in this world often say, 'The world is one of timely duties (*khaṇakicco loko*)—the world is one of timely duties.' They say this world is a place where

things must be done on time, a place that works by the moment. But the world does not know what the right moment is, and what the wrong moment is." Next, the Buddha declares, "Behold, monks, a Buddha is born in the world. He also teaches the Dhamma. But some person is born in hell. Then, even though a Buddha is born, one does not get the opportunity to realize Nibbāna. That is the wrong moment." That is to say, the Buddha points out eight situations where the timing can go wrong—non-opportune moments. Showing these eight, he says that one who is freed from these eight obtains the right moment during a time of a Buddha's appearance.

First, he said: a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. But this unfortunate person is born in hell. Then it is impossible to benefit from this Dhamma, to make an end of suffering. That is the first. Next, he declares—and this is similar: a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. But that person is born in the realm of hungry ghosts (*peta-loka*). Thirdly, he shows: a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. This person is an animal, in the animal realm. In such a situation too, it is impossible to travel along the path of Nibbāna and free oneself from the suffering of saṃsāra. Next, similarly, a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. Some person is born in a very long-lived celestial assembly—in a heaven world. While living indulged in the pleasures of that heaven world, they do not get the opportunity to practice the dispensational holy life (*brahmacariya*), develop the three characteristics—the three characteristics of impermanent (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*)—and make an end of the suffering of saṃsāra. That is difficult, due to various reasons like their celestial pleasures. The human world is indeed the best place to realize Nibbāna. Next, sometimes a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. But some person is born in a remote frontier region. It is usually said that Buddhas are born in the Middle Country (*Majjhima-desa*) of India. Then, the one born in that Middle Country has obtained a fortunate birth. That is to say, a situation existed in that region during the Buddha's time where one could hear the Dhamma as well as practice according to the Dhamma. If, during such a time, some person is born in a very remote place, where they do not even get to hear the Dhamma, and where the fourfold assembly of *bhikkhus*, *bhikkhunīs*, *upāsakas*, and *upāsikās* does not visit, such a person cannot benefit from this Dhamma. Then, that occasion too is not a right occasion. It is an unfortunate time. Next, sometimes a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. Some person lives in that very Middle Country itself. But that person is deeply of wrong view (*micchā-diṭṭhi*). He is blinded by a rigid wrong view. Such a person cannot benefit from the Dhamma. That situation is an unfortunate one. Next, it is shown: a Buddha is born and teaches the Dhamma. This person cannot be made to understand anything. He lacks wisdom. That is, a person whose wisdom has not matured. Such a person cannot

benefit from the Dhamma. In this way, that occasion too is an unfortunate one. Next, in the final occasion, some person is indeed highly wise. He is born in the Middle Country of India. All other factors are complete. But a Buddha has not arisen. The Dhamma is not taught. That is the eighth occasion.

In this manner, the Buddha declares: there are eight non-opportune moments. Escaping these eight moments, if one is born in a proper region during the time of a Buddha's appearance where one can hear the Dhamma and practice according to the Dhamma, without any sensory impairment, and possessed of wisdom—that, the Buddha declares, is an extremely rare moment, a rare opportunity. Therefore, what you have to think about yourselves is that you have obtained such a noble opportunity. The Buddha tells us not to waste this opportune moment (*khaṇa-sampatti*). If that moment is missed, if that opportunity is lost, the Buddha gives a simile: it is just like a merchant who had an opportunity to buy a commodity at a cheap price. Without taking advantage of it, he regrets it in the end. In the same way, one will have to regret—having obtained such an extremely rare opportunity in this incredibly long saṃsāra, during a period when one can benefit from the Dhamma, yet not taking advantage of it. What is meant by taking advantage? Realizing Nibbāna, making an end of the suffering of saṃsāra. At the very least, as mentioned, obtaining a supramundane state through the attainment of the Path of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti-magga*), which helps to escape the lower realms of misery. This is how we have to understand this verse.

That is why: *khaṇātītā hi socanti, nirayamhi samappitā*—if one lets this noble moment slip away, what happens to that person is that he falls into hell and suffers. He sorrows. Indeed, as we mentioned earlier, in this day and age we put so much effort into guarding the body, but because we are not interested in guarding the mind, this short lifespan is spent setting up various security measures, sometimes meeting death due to those very guards, and where do they end up being born? In the ghost realms (*peta-loka*), the yakkha realms, in bad destinations, or else in hell. We hear stories of births in such places in various ways. It is in such an extremely unfortunate era that we live. But virtuous people who reflect with wisdom must always think, in accordance with the Buddha's advice, that what is meant here by "self-protection" is the guarding of the mind. Guarding the mind means applying mindfulness (*sati*)—deploying that quality called mindfulness at those doors that come to the mind, the six doors connected to the mind—and assigning the sentry his proper duty in a manner relevant to one's own meditation. Regarding the conscious awareness called clear comprehension (*sampajañña*) that goes hand-in-hand with mindfulness, it is shown in the Dhamma in four ways. For someone practicing a meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*), they have to apply that conscious awareness in accordance

with that meditation subject. That is, when an object comes, they have to reflect in this way: is this object something that helps, something useful, something purposeful for the meditation subject I am practicing? Next, is it suitable (*sappāya*), is it proper, is it fitting for my meditation? One has to think in that way too. Likewise, one must also see whether one can maintain the meditation subject through every object on every occasion. Next, regarding the deceptive nature of this object—one must also obtain the ability to look at that object without that delusion. In this way, when reflecting deeply, just as that security guard maintains a considerable degree of conscious awareness in performing the task—the responsibility—belonging to him, the meditator, the one engaged in meditation, guards his meditation subject. The meditation subject is the only thing one has that needs to be guarded. It is through maintaining those meditation subjects that one can realize Nibbāna. That is why that clear comprehension (*sampajañña*)—this awareness, clear understanding—must be understood in a very broad manner. Thus, the objects that help to guard this mindfulness in this way are what the Buddha has declared as the Four Establishments of Mindfulness (*satipatṭhāna*). That is, what is spoken of here is not other things, external things. One establishes mindfulness on the very body received—this body. Next, in accordance with feelings (*vedanā*). Next, in accordance with the mind (*citta*)—the nature of the mind. One understands it in its respective ways. Next, in accordance with thoughts (*dhamma*) that come to the mind. In general, they can be taken as the body, feelings, the mind, and thoughts. Establishing mindfulness on these—on these—means constantly living in the present moment. Normally, people live either in the future or in the past. Thinking about what has to be done in the future, or else thinking about things that happened in the past, people generally live with a dead past and an unborn future. The Buddha has given advice to remove this tendency and to try as much as possible to live in the present.

There too, we can think about that sentry. If that sentry tries to run after someone who has already passed his guard post, he will not be able to perform the duty belonging to his post. Directing full attention for a brief moment, understanding the situation through inspection, he lets that person go. He stands ready for the next person. A skilled, alert sentry is always ready for each and every person who comes. Similarly, the person who has well-established his mindfulness understands the true nature of each and every incoming object as impermanent (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*), and lets them go. Why does he let them go? Because they are all things whose nature is to come and go, things of an impermanent nature. Understanding the impermanent as impermanent—this is through direct realization itself. By practicing mindfulness in this way, that wisdom gradually develops. Wisdom means

understanding. It is by understanding that everything existing in the entire world is of an impermanent nature that one can realize Nibbāna. Because within the world, there are distorted views. They are called "perversions" (*vipallāsa*)—four distorted views are mentioned: taking the impermanent (*anicca*) to be permanent (*nicca*); taking the foul (*asubha*) to be beautiful (*subha*); taking what is accompanied by suffering (*dukkha*) to be pleasurable (*sukha*); taking what is non-self (*anattā*), not one's own, to be one's self. It is within these four distorted views that people in the world live. The Buddha declares that beings travel long in this saṁsāra because of these four perversions, these distorted dhammas. Getting rid of this distorted state, getting rid of delusion, getting rid of ignorance (*avijjā*), the path of living in accordance with wisdom is indeed these Four Establishments of Mindfulness (*satipaṭṭhāna*). This is not something that costs much. It costs nothing at all. However, one has to make a certain sacrifice. One has to reconsider the things that people in the world—or rather, the ostentatious people of the world—think of as important and valuable in daily life, the values they themselves assign to them, and come to a certain conclusion in accordance with the Dhamma regarding them, and also regarding the way one's life is being spent. Now, normally, even though the Buddha described this lifespan as a single moment, people divide this life, this one small moment, and set it apart as "the final period of my life". Sometimes thinking that practicing meditation, keeping precepts, and so on are for the final period of life. But the Buddha always reminds us of diligence/heedfulness (*appamāda*), and also that there is no knowing when death will come. On one occasion, the Buddha spoke a verse that arouses spiritual urgency (*saṁvega*):

Ajjeva kiccamātappaṁ

ko jaññā maraṇaṁ suve

na hi no saṅgamaṁ tena

mahāsenena maccunā

—(*Bhaddekaratta Sutta, Majjhima Nikāya*)

If we translate this into Sinhala:

Do today indeed what is to be done,

Who knows, death may come tomorrow.

For there is indeed no bargaining for us,

With Death and his great army.

One cannot enter into an agreement with Death who has a great army, can we? Saying, "Give me a little time until I am free of my children, until I retire from my job, since I was unable to perform other meritorious deeds like Dhamma and meditation," or "I was unable to set aside time." One cannot make an agreement with Death in that way. That is the situation that exists in the world. That is why the wise human being, who has obtained a birth in a region where one can hear the Dhamma and practice according to the Dhamma during this time of a Buddha's appearance in this incredibly long saṃsāra, must consider this entire life as a single moment.

Then, that moment—that is indeed why it is said, "the world is one of timely duties (*khaṇakicco loko*)—the world is one of timely duties." Everyone says this world is a place where things must be done on time. Even in this day and age, in a city, we constantly hear this being said. In offices, and in other places. In places where worldly work is done, the talk is always of diligence. In the travel of vehicles, there too, the talk is of speed/haste. But in the journey of the Dhamma, in the journey of the Dispensation, regarding Dhamma and meditation, there is no such diligence there. Such is the situation in the world. The Buddha's vision is different from that. Now, to put it briefly, to establish that previously mentioned mindfulness, we sometimes have to perform even our daily activities slowly. Diligence (*appamāda*) in accordance with the Dhamma means bringing forth mindfulness regarding these. Therefore, to bring forth mindfulness, especially in the beginning, one sometimes has to maintain one's postures like a sick person. One has to perform those activities in that way. Why? Because objects come flowing in rapidly. When these are taken through a narrow gate, when they are made to pass through one by one, controlling them is easy. Therefore, doing each of these very slowly, sometimes, one has to gain a deep understanding of them. But if we look at the life stories of those highly-placed, very wealthy people who achieved what is called a successful life in the world, they did not spend their lives in that way. Grasping a vast amount of work, losing sleep, committing various wrongs, they gathered wealth. But the Dhamma does not speak of such a thing. Leaving aside that vast accumulation of wealth, turning to a simple/noble dress, according to the principle of "simple living and high thinking", even with difficulty, observing the precepts on a Poya day or a holiday, separating oneself for that purpose, one must test the truth of the Dhamma declared by the Buddha for oneself. One must practice it for oneself. If one spends even a single day in that way, one can obtain an experience entirely different from the experiences gained throughout a whole lifetime. That is why the Buddha declared: *paccattaṃ veditabbo viññūhi*—this Dhamma is to be understood by the wise, each for themselves. There are six terms describing this Dhamma that you frequently hear and recite. "Svākkhāto"—a well-expounded Dhamma. Why is it called well-

expounded? This Dhamma is well-declared not merely because the Buddha's Dhamma is sweet. Not merely because those words, that teaching, is extremely complete. It is well-expounded (*svākkhāto*) in a deep sense because one can obtain results by practicing that Dhamma. In a poorly-expounded (*durakkhāta*) doctrine, dispensation, or religion, the Buddha declared that the lazy person lives in comfort. In a well-expounded (*svākkhāto*) Dhamma, taught in the proper way, the Buddha declares that the energetic person lives in comfort. This is a deep idea. That is to say, in a doctrine taught in a wrong way as wrong view, if that person lives in the right way (by that doctrine's standards), that person goes to hell. Therefore, the lazy person lives in comfort there. But in this well-expounded Dhamma, it is the energetic person who can live in comfort, who lives in comfort. The lazy person lives in misery. The one who does not perform today indeed what is to be done—the previously mentioned task to be done—falls into regret. In this life too, and on his deathbed, he sorrows. Next, in a more terrible manner, as described in "falling into hell, he has to suffer," he has to suffer. Again, he has to seek the help of living relatives, visibly or invisibly, in various ways. Since such a situation exists in saṃsāra, in the world, the Buddha delivered these teachings on many occasions. Such is the quality of *Svākkhāto* (well-expounded) in this Dhamma.

"Sandiṭṭhiko" (to be seen for oneself) means: practicing this Dhamma as something directly experienced in this very life, one can test its success for oneself. Directly experienced (*sandiṭṭhika*). It is not a Nibbāna to be obtained in a next life that is expressed here, in the Buddha's Dhamma. In all other doctrines, what is called the ultimate goal, the highest thing, is shown as a state to be obtained after death. Our Buddha alone declared that this bliss of Nibbāna can be realized in this very life—*diṭṭheva dhamme* means in this very life—that making an end of the suffering of saṃsāra can be done in this very life. So, in that higher sense, it is not only the realization of the paths and fruits like Stream-entry. In daily life, in the manner we mentioned earlier, a person who sets aside even one day, maintaining postures slowly, practicing some meditation subject appropriate to their temperament, and testing the truth of those dhammas in accordance with the meditation subject, can develop faith (*saddhā*) in the Buddha within that single day. Not the faith mentioned in books, but from within oneself. Thinking, "The Buddha has taught such a Dhamma indeed!" That is *sandiṭṭhiko*. Next, "Akāliko" (timeless) means this Dhamma has the nature of yielding results without delay. This is not like giving a gift. For some things, when someone achieves a certain status, a gift is given for it. One has to present one's qualifications and wait until the gift is given. There is no such thing here. The result comes along with the completion of these factors. The Buddha showed this both in a very simple manner and in a deep manner. He has expressed it simply.

When a certain Brahmin asked on one occasion: "What, Venerable Sir, is the meaning of this sandiṭṭhiko, akāliko, ehipassiko?" the Buddha explained it to that Brahmin in a way that he could understand even while remaining in his status as a Brahmin. "Behold, Brahmin, suppose there is some greed in you. Understanding the value of generosity by applying some effort, suppose you have removed that greed. At that very moment, do you not realize: 'I suffered so much because of that greed. Now, because I have abandoned greed, I have obtained this much peace'? That indeed is what is meant by sandiṭṭhiko and akāliko. The result is obtained right there. One does not have to wait for this." Next, regarding aversion (*dosa*), it is the same. "Now, suppose you get angry with someone. You develop aversion. At the moment that aversion arises, your face changes completely, it becomes distorted, and you experience some suffering and displeasure because of that aversion. If you remove that aversion through thoughts of loving-kindness (*mettā*) and so on, if you remove it through compassion (*karuṇā*), at that moment you obtain a great peace. Then, you get to experience it right there." Regarding delusion (*moha*) too, it is the same. If, at the moment delusion arose, one established mindfulness and acted accordingly. If one reflected properly at that moment, the benefit of that wisdom is right there. Thus, in a general sense, it is so. When looked at in a deep sense, along with the completion of the Noble Eightfold Path, the fruit of Stream-entry is obtained. The Buddha does not have to come and say, "Here, I am giving you Stream-entry." There is no such thing. What is expressed there is that it is inherent in the Dhamma itself, and is obtained by practicing the Dhamma. "Akāliko"—it yields results without delay.

"Ehipassiko" (inviting to come and see) means: come and see. It says, "come and see." It is not the Buddha who says "come and see," but the Dhamma itself. This Dhamma calls out, "Practice me and see." Therefore, it is the Dhamma that becomes ehipassiko here. "Come - see." "Come and see, practice and see." In this way, it makes an invitation. "Opanayiko" (leading onwards) means the nature of this Dhamma is such that one thing is connected to another in a wonderful way, according to the relationship of cause and condition (*hetu-paccaya*). Now, someone can easily understand that. A person who had wrong view, having heard the Dhamma from the Buddha, having understood good arguments, having understood the wholesome and the unwholesome, and having gained some understanding of the Four Noble Truths, develops Right View (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) to some extent at that point. Along with that Right View, good thoughts arise in that person. Thinking, "Renunciation (*nekkhamma*) is good—leaving behind is good. Harmlessness is good. Loving-kindness is good," and in that direction, thoughts of loving-kindness, such good thoughts arise. That is Right Thought (*sammā-saṅkappa*). That is why the Buddha declares: *sammādiṭṭhissa

sammāsaṅkappo pahoti*—in the person who has Right View, Right Thought—good thoughts—arise naturally, spontaneously, without effort. In that way, instead of remaining in lay life with stinginess, "how valuable a thing is renunciation—that nekkhamma?" Next, similarly, getting rid of harm and maintaining thoughts of harmlessness, thoughts of compassion—how valuable a thing is that? Getting rid of anger and thoughts of loving-kindness. In that way, through those thoughts, that person obtains benefits at that very moment. Therein lies "opanayiko"—it leads onwards from one to another. In the one who has Right View, Right Thought arises. In the one who has Right thoughts, good words come out of his mouth accordingly. Truthful words, words that reconcile others, gentle words, words in accordance with the Dhamma, come out of his mouth. Then, *sammāsaṅkappassa sammāvācā pahoti*—in the one who has good thoughts, good wishes, because of those very good thoughts and wishes, good words come out from within that person. Next, *sammāvācassa sammākammanto pahoti*—the person who purifies Right Speech thinks, "I maintain these thoughts of renunciation, thoughts of loving-kindness, thoughts of harmlessness in this way." That is how thoughts are purified. That is how words are purified. Therefore, "killing living beings, stealing, sexual misconduct, etc., do not suit me," and in this way, there is naturally an abstaining from them as well. Next, doing so not just for a day or two, but as Right Livelihood (*sammā-ājīva*)—one molds one's livelihood and lifestyle accordingly, even if one has to make some sacrifice. Thinking, "These are not things to be kept occasionally only on Poya days. I must correct my very livelihood, my entire lifestyle, according to this declared path," that person becomes energetic and establishes Right Livelihood. The correct way of living. So, the person who has a correct way of living, through the effort he exerts, next develops what is called Right Effort (*sammā-vāyāma*)—the correct exertion. Correct exertion is not about engaging in some work until one sweats profusely. What is correct effort? It is the fourfold effort of remaining highly attentive to the mind, preventing unwholesome states that are ready to flow into the mind, discarding unwholesome states already present in the mind, bringing close wholesome states, and consolidating those good wholesome states present within oneself. This is the effort that arises in the person who makes some sacrifice for his livelihood and establishes a righteous way of living. Then, through that very effort, this person next falls naturally into that previously mentioned satipaṭṭhāna. The Four Establishments of Mindfulness are completed. Why? Because that person is constantly examining his own mind. About the body that acts in accordance with that mind. The body and the mind act in connection with each other. The ordinary person is subservient to the body and disregards the mind. The Buddha, in accordance with the Dhamma teaching *manopubbaṅgamā dhammā*, shows that the mind is the forerunner. Now, in the book called the Dhammapada, shown as the beginning of many verses

declared by the Buddha—as the door to that treasury of gems—is:

manopubbaṅgamā dhammā, manoseṭṭhā manomayā—mind is the forerunner of all things, mind is supreme, they are mind-made. Everything is preceded by the mind. The mind is chief. Everything is made of the mind. No one can prove this to be false. Even a worldly scientist cannot prove this to be false. Such a wonderful teaching. That is why the Buddha gave the foremost place to the mind. *Cittena nīyati loko*—the Buddha declared. The entire world is led by the mind. Now, normally, is it not with the mind that people in the world think of these things? That scientist does those things in the laboratory with the mind. Therefore, it is with the mind that all of this is led. Going to the moon is also done with the mind. All of this is done with the mind. Some people might misunderstand these things and explain them in a distorted way. But what is here is that the mind is chief in everything. That statement made by the Buddha is always a truth.

Cittena nīyati loko (the world is led by the mind), that is indeed why the Buddha gives the foremost place to the mind itself.

If that correct vision called Right View has arisen within someone to any extent, the sequence of dhammas arising from there is called the Noble Eightfold Path. The Buddha has declared that this path is superior to all paths in the entire world. There are various kinds of wide paths, paths where one can travel in comfortable vehicles, various kinds of paths in the world. But the Buddha declares, *maggānaṭṭhaṅgiko seṭṭho*—the path consisting of eight factors is the best. In that way, if this mindfulness is completed through the Four Establishments of Mindfulness, concentration (*samādhi*) also grows naturally within such a person. By directing the mind to a single object, while that sentry applies mindfulness well to each thing, concentration arises within him, even if only for that brief moment. He can then maintain it for a long period. Indeed, it is through completing this Noble Eightfold Path that one can realize this noble Dhamma of Nibbāna, free oneself from all the suffering of saṃsāra, and find peace in that deathless supreme bliss of Nibbāna. Therefore, today is a valuable Poya day. The day the Buddha set the Wheel of Dhamma in motion (*Dhamma-cakka-pavattana*). Thus, one must endeavor to set this Wheel of Dhamma in motion within one's own mental continuum (*citta-santāna*) and free oneself from this mass of suffering. Today, then, on this valuable day, established in virtue (*sīla*)—or in a highly valuable virtue—you have heard this Dhamma in this manner, for about an hour. During this period, you may have been able to realize those previously mentioned dhammas to some extent, according to your store of merit (*puñña-shakti*) and store of wisdom (*ñāṇa-shakti*). To put it briefly, if this time had been spent on other things, worldly things, such a

peaceful, pure collection of thoughts would not have arisen. Thus indeed, one must understand the value of the Dhamma as sandiṭṭhiko and akāliko.

Now then, this is a store of merit you have gathered by listening to the Dhamma for this long. As benefits, in the manner declared by the Buddha, the qualities of faith (*saddhā*), energy (*vīriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) can be experienced by you at this very moment. Having sat in this posture during this time with a certain degree of faith, and with energy following that, and establishing mindfulness accordingly, you heard the Dhamma and experienced a certain concentration. Next, if some understanding of the Dhamma arose, wisdom is developed by that. When reflecting in this way, traveling along this path of Dhamma gradually, even little by little, one must firmly resolve to take the maximum benefit from this human life—the maximum benefit from this opportune moment (*khaṇa-sampatti*). Having firmly resolved thus, as the benefit of this vast store of merit gathered by listening to the Dhamma, one must wish: "May this give me the strength and power to realize the deathless supreme Nibbāna in this very life, as quickly as possible, through the paths and fruits of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti*), Once-returning (*sakadāgāmī*), Non-returning (*anāgāmī*), and Arahatsip."

Likewise, this store of merit gathered so far—gathered by both of us through this teaching of Dhamma and hearing of Dhamma—may the assembly of deities who protect the Dispensation, and whatever deities reside in this sacred place, joyfully rejoice in it! May everyone realize the noble deathless supreme Nibbāna through their own aspired Bodhi (Enlightenment)! May they provide protection to us and to the Dispensation! Thus indeed, one must share the merit with the deities.

Likewise, one's departed relatives, including all beings from the Avīci hell up to the Akanītha heaven who desire merit and desire Nibbāna—may they all rejoice in our merit of teaching and hearing the Dhamma! Having rejoiced, may they be freed from all suffering states, reach happy states, and by practicing Dhamma and meditation as quickly as possible, find peace in the noble deathless supreme Nibbāna! With this aspiration, recite these verses and transfer the merit.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”